ORAL HISTORY TRANSCRIPT

Walter Mendygral Oral History - Side A

Interview with Walter Mendygral about joining the Army Air Corps, military training, and his World War II service.

IDENTIFIER	CORHC-0006	**RUNTIME**	47:53
INTERVIEWEE	Walter Mendygral	**INTERVIEWER**	Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
PARTICIPANT	Josephine Mendygral	**RECORDING**	Side A | English

Transcript note. This transcript was generated using automated speech recognition and then reviewed. Speaker names, spelling, and selected wording have been corrected. Bracketed unclear passages mark audio that could not be transcribed confidently. The audio recording remains the primary source.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:02

You don't-don't be afraid to talk slow. I've got to write everything down.

00:08

Go ahead. What were you gonna say? Oh, did you choose to join the Air Force, or did you just get placed there?

Walter Mendygral
00:18

No, I joined the Army first. Because I knew they were gonna call me. So I figured I'd have a better choice of where I went.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:27

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
00:31

I was learning how to fly before I went.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:35

Oh you did?

Walter Mendygral
00:37

So I went when I went to Camp Grant.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:43

What now what's that?

Walter Mendygral
00:43

I beg your pardon?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:45

What is Camp Grant?

Walter Mendygral
00:48

It's an Army base-what they call an induction center.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:54

So that's where you went to go sign up for it.

Walter Mendygral
00:56

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:57

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
01:02

They had only the Air Corps. They didn't have the Air Forces at that time.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:10

Ok.

Walter Mendygral
01:13

So when I went to join the Army, they put me in the section where the Air Corps men were supposed to be. In the meantime-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:26

So wait, you say you didn't choose that, so they just happened to put you where you would have liked to have been. Okay.

01:55

So you chose so you kind of avoided the draft, in other words.

Walter Mendygral
01:58

Yeah, I avoided the draft.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:00

Uh-huh.

Walter Mendygral
02:01

But in Camp Grant they had National Guard personnel-personnel that were working there, giving us our clothes, our haircuts, whatever we needed. All the buttons were cut off, and all the, you know, what they would call identification marks from what Army you were in were pulled off. Well, when you got in there, you had to use the money you had to-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:45

From being in the Army already? When you said they had all the ID marks off-

Walter Mendygral
02:53

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:53

Does that mean you were already in the Army, and then you went to Camp Grant, and then they're kind of starting all over, placing you again?

Walter Mendygral
02:56

Yeah. Well, I was there, and I had to get my clothes, my shoes, and that.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
03:06

Mm-hmm. Is this when you've been in the Army, or you're just going to sign up?

Walter Mendygral
03:11

When you're going there, you sign-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
03:12

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
03:15

-sign up, and then they give you the clothes. But they tell you where to go to change clothes, and over there, there was personnel from the National Guard directing. As they directed you, they told you how much money you should have.

03:42

If you came with any money, and how much. And then they told you where to go to have the buttons sewn on and identification put on the shirts and pants and shoes before you could go out-the barracks to stay. Um-

04:13

By the time they finished with you, you were broke. Well, they told you to bring some money. I brought, I think, about twenty dollars, and that was all gone. They charged you for everything they did. You were in the Army; they were supposed to do it. But this is the National Guard, and they were making money on me.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
04:40

Okay. So they told you to bring money, was it just to pay for everything

Walter Mendygral
04:46

No. When you went into the Army, everything was supposed to be given free-your clothes and everything.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
04:53

So you're supposed to have your own spending money

Walter Mendygral
04:57

Well, they took whatever money you had, and they put you in a barracks, and they told you to wait until-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
05:00

Yeah.

Walter Mendygral
05:08

-they came up with the schedule you were going to have. When they told you the schedule, it happened to be around Thanksgiving Day. They told you, you can get three or four days off if you want, but they ain't gonna pay you until after you come back.

05:34

So I took three days off. I hitchhiked from Camp Grant home to Chicago.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
05:43

Something else.

Walter Mendygral
05:47

I told my dad about what I did. They had nothing to say about it, 'cause they knew what the Army was doing at the time. I told them what I made. I suppose that's the only way I could get it fast. I wanted to see them once before I got shipped out.

06:16

So after that, I got my three-day pass, and I went back. I didn't know the roads around here or nothing. Had a hard time. But I had an identification card from the Army directing me where to go.

Josephine Mendygral
06:40

Your ID and your driver's license was set to expire in 1942. Bringing your driver's licene/id card specific only driver's services to school for your birthday, I guess.

Walter Mendygral
06:59

Why are you telling me that?

07:04

I told you, leave the goddamn paper.

Josephine Mendygral
07:07

All right, all right, I don't need it.

Walter Mendygral
07:08

I don't wanna know anything. I'm not gonna go through a driver's license. Why do you bother me?

Josephine Mendygral
07:16

[Unclear]

Walter Mendygral
07:24

What do you want to know now?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
07:26

Um, you were saying that you were coming back to Camp Grant and you know you didn't know the roads very well.

Walter Mendygral
07:31

Oh.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
07:32

You had your ID telling you where to go.

Walter Mendygral
07:34

So when I got back to camp, kind of late, I just went to the barracks. I was supposed to call in and wait for instructions. Some guy with a sergeant's badge came in. He says this and this and those and them, and to be ready in the morning. They didn't say what time. Five o'clock in the morning-it wasn't even daylight yet-they woke you up, and we went for a march.

08:18

We came back about two hours later, went to eat, then we were supposed to get-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
08:29

Your your what?

Walter Mendygral
08:30

Our pay money.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
08:31

Oh money. Okay. Oh that's right, because you get paid when you come back and leave.

Walter Mendygral
08:38

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
08:38

Mm-hmm.

Walter Mendygral
08:45

So at that time

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
08:46

You can turn it up girl if you want.

Walter Mendygral
08:49

At that time they were paying the GIs twenty-one dollars a month. Twenty-one dollars a month.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
09:05

Um, when you went home, were you allowed to-like, when you talked to your parents or when you talked to anyone-were you allowed to tell them whatever you wanted to about the Army, or were there restrictions?

Walter Mendygral
09:17

Oh, yeah. Well, you're in the Army, so what can they do?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
09:22

'Cause I heard that when the veterans came to visit our class, I guess a few of 'em said that they had people looking at their mail, 'cause they really couldn't say anything about what they were doing, what was going on in the Army, or anything.

Walter Mendygral
09:38

Oh, then, yeah. Before you could mail anything, you had to show them what you wrote, and you had to buy the stamps from them.

Josephine Mendygral
09:53

[Unclear]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
10:04

So, then, like, who checked the mail?

Walter Mendygral
10:09

The National Guard.

10:24

All this stuff was supposed to be done for you in the Army as instructions. They wanted to get paid for everything they did because that was their only income, too. They got twenty-one dollars a month, too. They figured they'd, if they busted us, they'd have more. So then they gave us our instructions-where to go and eat, where we should get a

haircut, things like that. Some of the kids that got in there, they never ate anything out of the house.

11:07

They didn't know. When they gave us breakfast, they said breakfast-this was-and they called it a name. Well, you went in there, you had breakfast; by the time you got out, you had the runs. So while you were walking back to your barracks, you had to crap wherever you could.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

11:41

You serious? Everyone would just kind of stop and-

Walter Mendygral

11:50

And if you're complaining, who can you complain to? The National Guard. What do the National Guard do? They're running the Army.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

12:02

What is-? No, not at all. If you want to turn it up a little bit, fine. Um, so what did you eat? Did you know what it was?

Walter Mendygral

12:11

Shit

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

12:12

That's okay, so it was just kind of slop.

Josephine Mendygral

12:14

You can't tell them that, still.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

12:16

I'll put that as a quote in my paper from you whenever

Josephine Mendygral

12:21

Lamb. A lot of lamb.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

12:23

Lamb? Ground meat? Ground-

Josephine Mendygral

12:24

That shit on a shingle-that's what he said, lamb.

Walter Mendygral

12:26

There was ground meat on there.

Josephine Mendygral
12:30

It was lamb, wasn't it? Because to this day, you won't eat lamb.

Walter Mendygral
12:33

Well, whatever, it was, I don't know.

Josephine Mendygral
12:37

You always said it was lamb

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
12:39

Okay. Wonder why they chose lamb.

Walter Mendygral
12:45

Well, all the beef was sold because Europe didn't have any beef.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
12:50

Uh huh.

Walter Mendygral
12:51

So they sold all the beef to Europe.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
12:54

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
12:55

So we had no beef to buy. You know, so in Europe they raised lambs and chickens and

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
13:02

Yeah.

Walter Mendygral
13:05

Things like that. Like in Italy-in Italy, to this day, they-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
13:10

I'm okay. I ate junk yesterday.

Walter Mendygral
13:18

-eat mostly veal because they kill the animals when they're born, after a week's time.

13:31

They send you to a barber to get a haircut. They charge you money for the haircut.

13:40

And then after they charged you, they asked, what did you want? A hair wash, or whatever they called it-I forget the names they called it. So you go over there to the barber shop. The guy told you, pay up in advance. So you paid in advance. They took practically all the money you had. They left you a little bit for the next place that you went. Then they told you to go back to the barracks, get some rest, because you're gonna go on a march. And that's all we did was march for the next two weeks.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

14:32

So what's so what's a march?

Walter Mendygral

14:35

March. Oh

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

14:36

You just so you learn how to march.

Walter Mendygral

14:39

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

14:41

Is it is it

Walter Mendygral

14:41

They told you what foot to use, when to use it, how to use it, and-and shoestrings. They were selling the shoestrings a dollar a set.

Josephine Mendygral

14:56

A pair.

Walter Mendygral

14:58

Well, whatever you want to call it, right? They called it a set.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

15:04

So did you learn just how to march or like use guns or

Walter Mendygral

15:07

Well, it took a long time for people to get organized, because the people that joined the Army-they were illiterate, most of them. They came without shoes. They had to buy their shoes, do everything the hard way. They made sure you were broke in the first week after you got paid.

Josephine Mendygral
15:41

Yeah, I can't help you, because I really don't know what happened to him. He ended up flying.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
15:48

[Unclear]

Walter Mendygral
15:51

Uh, where do I get to that?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
15:52

What kind of flying was it?

Josephine Mendygral
15:53

In the Air Corps

Walter Mendygral
15:56

They took the people that were in the Air Corps, and they sent them to Biloxi, Mississippi.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
16:05

Do you have any idea how to spell that or no?

Walter Mendygral
16:08

Well, we didn't know what it was. They sent us out to the beach there. That was about five thousand men.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
16:17

So you were sent there.

Walter Mendygral
16:18

Keesler.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
16:19

Oh.

Walter Mendygral
16:23

You were supposed to take lectures every day on that field. It was on a beach. That was around the start of December. Well, that's December the 7th. We were out there listening to the doctors and what they were supposed to be for.

16:52

They were going to medical school, so they were giving you examinations, drilling holes in your tooth and everything else. That was their occupation. All right. Then they told us-

17:13

-to go out there and march every day. They gave you broomsticks-just the sticks, no broom. Those were our guns.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
17:25

Okay,

Walter Mendygral
17:27

So one day, about eleven o'clock, just before noon, we were marching. Somebody came out there with a big broadcast machine.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
17:39

Wait, when was this? December wait.

Walter Mendygral
17:42

December seventh

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
17:43

Oh

Walter Mendygral
17:47

That's when we found out that the Japanese attacked us at Pearl Harbor, and they were gonna send us to some schools because we were all supposedly ready to fly, and they were gonna teach us.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
18:10

So you signed up for the Army before the U.S. was even involved in the war, and you wanted to sign up so that you wouldn't get drafted. But did you just presume or figure the U.S. was going to get involved soon, so you might as well, or-

Walter Mendygral
18:25

Nobody said that we were in the Army, but they were drafting everybody.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
18:31

Oh really? So you saw that and so you signed up because you thought you'd be drafted.

Walter Mendygral
18:35

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
18:36

Okay. All right. Huh. Well, evidently, they had a good feeling then that there'd be a war, if they were drafting people.

Walter Mendygral

18:46

Well, they didn't get into war until we were attacked at Pearl Harbor. Then President Roosevelt said that we are at war against the Japanese. Well, we were shipping a lot of stuff that was being manufactured in this country, in the factories. They were shipping it to the East Coast and the West Coast, and the ships were taking it overseas. On the West Coast, they went to Russia, and on the East Coast, they went to Britain. And we were in the Air-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

19:26

Mm-hmm.

Walter Mendygral

19:28

-Corps, not the Air Forces.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

19:29

Mm-hmm. Should I say Air Force or Air Corps? Sorry. Air Corps. Ok.

Walter Mendygral

19:38

When they decided what to do with us, they took us out in the field about a week later, and they told us where we were going, or where we cared to go.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

19:53

So they you had a choice too. Or no.

Walter Mendygral

19:55

Oh yeah, you had a choice.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

19:57

Out of

Walter Mendygral

19:58

You didn't know what the choice was. They called your name out, and they asked you where you wanted to go, and they gave you the names of the schools. Most of them were in the Army.

Josephine Mendygral

20:17

[Unclear]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

20:19

You mean, like infantry? Wait, but okay, at this point you're in the Air Corps, and you were being asked-like, you were still going to be in the Air Corps, but you had a choice of where-

Walter Mendygral

20:31

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
20:33

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
20:33

You were gonna be taught some kind of a job that you were gonna do in the Army.

20:43

Then about a week later, they got an adjutant, and they told us that they were opening up a new branch in the Army, which was the Air Forces, someplace in Colorado. But in the meantime, you were supposed to go to school where they were gonna send you. You had a choice, and you knew where these places would be. Most of the guys took the choices close to home. We were in the Midwestern states, but they sent most of the people down south to school, or east.

Josephine Mendygral
21:39

[Unclear]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
21:40

So, okay, so-

Walter Mendygral
21:41

There were about fifty of us that were from Chicago, and none of us made a decision.

Josephine Mendygral
21:53

[Unclear]

Walter Mendygral
21:55

So since we didn't make no decision, they were gonna decide for us.

22:03

When we found out the next day where we were going, we were going back to Chicago

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
22:11

Wait, okay. So you guys are from Chicago and you and you how come you didn't make a choice on where to go?

Walter Mendygral
22:19

The choices were made by the Army for-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
22:22

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
22:23

They told you-like me. They told me I was good. I was one of the last ones that volunteered for anything. And they looked at my record and said, "You never went to high school. How did you learn to fly?" I said I went to school, and all that bung. Then they sent me to a school on Michigan Avenue and 13th Street.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
22:52

So

Walter Mendygral
22:52

And I stayed at the YMCA in the Army.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
22:56

How come you didn't stay at home? Was it too far to go every day? Oh, so that's just where the Army had you stay. Okay.

Walter Mendygral
23:05

You had to go where they told you. So then you went to school. I went to school, I think about, for four months.

23:19

So that was December, and around Christmas time, we went home to Chicago, so we could get a couple of days off. But we had to report.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
23:34

But you were in Chicago already for school.

Walter Mendygral
23:36

Yeah

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
23:37

Okay. But everyone else came back too

Walter Mendygral
23:39

Yeah. Well, all the people got shipped to the places they wanted, or what they decided before that.

23:51

So they decided for you; that's where you went. In the meantime, they told us about the war and what was happening. We were taking a terrible beating.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
24:06

Mm-hmm. So do they keep you well informed about what was going on in the war and stuff or not so much?

Walter Mendygral
24:11

Well, every day about four o'clock p.m., they had a station on the radio that would notify all the people in Chicago what was going on with the war.

24:33

I went to this school on 13th and Michigan to learn how to be a mechanic.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

24:41

On an airplane

Walter Mendygral

24:51

Yeah.

24:55

They had civilian teachers teaching us, which was all right.

25:10

In the meantime, I wanted off to go to a wedding. So one of my cousins, who happened to be uh-

25:30

I mean, I think it's in February.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

25:33

Isn't that when you met Grandma?

Walter Mendygral

25:35

Yeah

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

25:35

February fourteenth. Can you guys let it down?

25:47

So wait, were you on leave again?

Walter Mendygral

25:50

Well, we weren't-we weren't. I mean, you'd go to school for about five hours a day, then you went back to your hotel.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

26:00

Okay.

Walter Mendygral

26:00

Where you wanted to go, I guess, you were free to go.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

26:02

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
26:06

You were supposed to stay

26:11

But the teachers were very, very fair. We all liked them. We took the tests, and we got our directions where to go to work. I wound up being sent to Chicago Midway Airport. We were taking the seats out of the airplanes that the government had bought from the airlines-taking the seats out of the planes so that they could use them for shipping, you know, war material.

27:12

In the meantime, my wife-I suppose she was my girlfriend-she was standing by me.

27:26

Carry stuff out of one hangar to another hangar. We could just see friends of ours. Nobody was stopped. There were too many of us. Anyway, I think I graduated sometime in June.

27:53

And I was sent to Kellogg Field, Michigan.

28:04

I was classified as a crew chief.

28:16

And the planes that we were working on were planes that the Army had bought from the civilian companies, and most of them were passenger planes.

28:41

And we were supposed to work on these planes until called, which they started to call us.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
28:49

What does "called" mean?

Walter Mendygral
28:51

Well, we were supposed to be mechanics on B-17s, which were being shipped-

Josephine Mendygral
28:57

[Unclear]

Walter Mendygral
29:01

-to Bangor, Maine, or someplace around in Canada. I took the East Coast.

29:13

So I used to fly on these planes over Lake Michigan-this, that, those and these-and then the things that were supposed to be done. We had mechanics on there that were already Army mechanics, and we were learning from them.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
29:35

Sure. So, you wanted to take these planes-you had to, since they had to go to Maine, so you had to fly them to Maine. You had the choice of two places, and you chose to fly them to Maine. Is that what you're saying?

Walter Mendygral
29:48

We were flying. I went in the eastern group at Kellogg Field, and we would fly about three a day over to Bangor, Maine. From Bangor, Maine, they tried to stay on the part that goes around the North Pole, so they wouldn't fly over water too much, because the Germans at that time had a lot of submarines with guns that would shoot at you.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
30:22

Try it.

Walter Mendygral
30:26

So this way they could get into England or anywhere like that. So this was what they called the safe route, and they shipped the planes to England.

30:42

We were not knowing that England [unclear] of the country. And once the planes got there, they were shipped either to France or English airports, and they used them for bombing missions. We didn't go on those. They had the regular personnel. So we were just bringing the planes to Bangor, Maine, and then these other people took the planes and flew them to the airports that needed them. And they were trying to use them against Germany.

31:44

But the war wasn't declared against Germany. There was a war that was declared against the Axis. They called them Axis.

32:06

So anyway, that was our first training for airplanes. Then I was flying over Lake Michigan. We were throwing sacks of flour out as bombs to see how we could hit the area. So that was-yeah. In the meantime, after that, I lost track of where I went, because I was going from one field to another. But I was stationed-my home base was Kellogg Field, Michigan. I was close to-close to what you call-

33:02

It was, like, next to Canada.

Josephine Mendygral
33:05

Forget it.

Walter Mendygral
33:12

And then, after a certain amount of training, they shipped us to airports which needed mechanics. So, I don't know, I traveled everywhere-from one to here to there. That's when we found out that the Air Force was gonna be inaugurated in 1942.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
33:42

Oh, the Air Force is going to come about-like, instead of an Air Corps, an Air Force now.

Walter Mendygral
33:46

Yeah, yeah.

33:56

That's where they started looking for pilots.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
34:02

So the Air Corps-what's the difference between the Air Corps and the Air Force?

Walter Mendygral
34:08

Well, the Air Corps was part of the Army. That was from World War I. The Air Force now was supposed to be independently operated for the Air Forces.

Josephine Mendygral
34:26

[Unclear]

Walter Mendygral
34:27

The Air Forces.

Josephine Mendygral
34:30

Is it for better or worse?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
34:32

So it was kind of more serious about it.

Walter Mendygral
34:36

Well, they were teaching them in Colorado. They had a school where they were teaching the people that were flying them-

34:48

-mathematics and seeing distances and-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
34:54

And this is probably too because in World War One, you know, they just didn't probably have as many planes around. So they

Walter Mendygral
35:02

They did, because they were shipping-England brought up what they could to use.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
35:03

Yeah.

Walter Mendygral
35:09

So, a new set of planes were demolished, and the ones that weren't, they used them for... they used them to throw bombs out-push them out the hatch. They didn't know how to do it.

35:51

Okay

35:55

Then they were shipping us from one air base to another base to get us accustomed to the way the Air Forces ran the bases. Most of us were all privates. Then they started designating, like, private first class and corporals and men.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

36:24

What was what was your title?

Walter Mendygral

36:27

Well I didn't have any title yet.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

36:29

Okay.

Walter Mendygral

36:30

All I was was a mechanic. And then they decided to send us to these different places. We were supposed to learn how to fly, how to be mechanics. The whole course was about a year long. Then you traveled from the East Coast to the West Coast, south, back east. Then you were stationed in what they called a squadron.

Josephine Mendygral

37:07

[Unclear]

Walter Mendygral

37:15

The names of the places that you were gonna work in, and your number classification-they called that the MOS, the-what?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

37:25

Okay, so then you were put into a number classification called the MOS. You were put into a number classification at this point, called the MOS, when you were taking this course.

Walter Mendygral

37:35

Yeah. And from the group that they had, they tried to pick out future pilots. So I wound up going to-I forget the name-in Phoenix, Arizona. Southwest Airways. That's where they started making us soldiers for the Air Corps.

38:45

Well, I was in Phoenix for about a month. Then they shipped us out to be mechanics.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

38:53

What year are we in right now? What year is it?

Walter Mendygral

38:56

This is forty-two.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
38:57

Okay. So you were shipped out to what?

Walter Mendygral
39:04

We were shipped to Phoenix, and that's what-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
39:05

Uh-huh.

Walter Mendygral
39:07

We learned to be soldiers for the Air Force, which-all of us had MOS's. I think, 707 or 747.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
39:21

Is that the plane you flew?

Walter Mendygral
39:23

Well, the pilots were 747 MOS, and-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
39:23

That's your-oh.

Walter Mendygral
39:30

Mechanics were 707. That was our breakdown-what we were trained to do. So when I went, what was the name, to Phoenix-Southwest Airways-

39:56

I got the books there. I think I gave you one of them.

40:12

And from that day on, I was either learning to fly or working as a mechanic.

40:30

We didn't have many airplanes because they were all gone, so we had mostly classroom lessons.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
40:43

So, did you not get to be in a plane flying very much then?

Walter Mendygral
40:49

No, because they had to send you to preflight. That took about three months. You learned all the rules, and then, after that, you learned to fly PT planes. After that-about twenty hours-then you got to fly faster planes. And there were four categories. There were fighter pilots, which they needed badly, and then there were transports, which they needed

also, and everybody needed fighter and bomber pilots. I was broken in on a B-17.

41:47

I wanted a B-17. But my instructor-

41:54

-insisted that I be a fighter pilot. Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
41:58

So you wanted the B-17. Why? How come the B-17?

Walter Mendygral
42:07

Because I already knew the plane.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
42:09

Okay. Is that what you had learned to fly?

Walter Mendygral
42:11

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
42:12

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
42:16

They insisted I be in a super plane,-you know, fighter pilot.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
42:21

Wait, we thought they wanted you to be a fighter pilot.

Walter Mendygral
42:29

And I was told if I didn't want to do a job that was dangerous, I didn't have to. So I told him I wanted to be a bomber pilot. They were not looking for bomber pilots until later years.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
42:52

Isn't which is more dangerous, the fighter pilot or the bomber?

Walter Mendygral
42:56

Well, on the bomber, you could be a gunner. There were different categories. You could be a pilot, copilot, and whatnot. But you had to put a lot of hours in, and that's the way you learned how to be a pilot for the Air Force.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
43:18

By putting a lot of hours in on the plane trying to fly it.

Walter Mendygral
43:22

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
43:22

So now, okay, so you wanted to be on a B-17, and they wanted you to be a fighter pilot. So then-and that was safer? That's why?

Walter Mendygral
43:32

No, no

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
43:33

But you didn't have to do something dangerous on the plane

Walter Mendygral
43:36

I didn't have to do anything dangerous as long as I was in this country. If I was shipped overseas, then I had to do what they told me.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
43:46

Okay, so when you were here, you had a choice. Now, did you have a choice in being shipped over-somewhat of a choice-or did they just tell you you are-

Walter Mendygral
43:49

At that time-well, they didn't need bomber pilots because they needed fighter pilots in England. So they taught us on these fast planes. I think the P-47 was what they were teaching me. I didn't care for them. They were too fast. The airplane used to fly about four hundred miles an hour, so they sent me to the P-47.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
44:24

What was that plane called again?

Walter Mendygral
44:34

But I didn't want that, so they had no choice. They had to court-martial me.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
44:40

Okay, oh, wait a second. That's right, because when you were flying, the guy gave you an order, but you didn't follow it-or you couldn't follow it-so then they court-martialed you. Is that what you're talking about? Like, if you were flying by some mountains or something, and some guy told you to do something.

Walter Mendygral
44:57

Yeah, that's when they took you into the mountains of Arizona, and they told you-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
45:01

Yeah, can you explain that situation? Mm-hmm.

Walter Mendygral
45:06

-to fly, you know, pick your places-how you would get out of mountains, and the plane couldn't fly high enough, and this and that and those and these. Well, in the meantime, the guy occupied my time so much that I got myself-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
45:30

Wait, what do you mean he occupied your time so much?

Walter Mendygral
45:35

And I wasn't thinking what I was doing.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
45:38

So he was like giving you directions.

Walter Mendygral
45:40

No, and he wasn't giving me directions. He let me fly where I wanted to. Then he told me get out of there, and now it's my turn to get out of it. Well, I had no choice.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
45:52

So he told you to get out of there and you didn't have much of a choice of how to do it.

Walter Mendygral
45:56

That's right.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
45:59

Who is this guy?

Walter Mendygral
46:01

He was my instructor.

46:06

He was an instructor from Texas, from the Army.

Josephine Mendygral
46:10

[Unclear]

Walter Mendygral
46:14

They were all hotrods.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
46:19

So did you have, like, a time limit, or were you running out of gas? Because he's telling you to do something, and you didn't have enough time to do it, so you did it the way you wanted.

Walter Mendygral
46:27

Well, I couldn't-I couldn't get out of it. I didn't know how to get out of it. And I told him, "Well, you put me in a position that I can't get out of. Now how am I gonna get out of it?" I don't remember. He got me so mad, I started to argue with him. And he turned the radio on so they could hear that I was arguing with him at the station there.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
46:58

Mm-hmm. So, okay, he was telling you to get out of the situation.

Walter Mendygral
46:59

And they court-martialed me.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
47:07

You didn't know how, and then you had an argument with him because all he did was talk and wasn't helping you. Is that right?

Walter Mendygral
47:15

Yeah. So I got shut out of flying.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
47:27

Okay, hold on one thing.

Josephine Mendygral
47:39

Hey, making up stories.

Walter Mendygral
47:40

What is that?

End of Side A. Side B is available separately in the Carrie Gabaree Digital Archive. Repository: Carrie Gabaree Digital Archive.